

The Crazy Train Is Optional

Robert J. Lammert

Essay

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You can refuse the Kool-Aid without hating the people drinking it.

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The grocery store self-checkout is a dangerous place to learn about modern America.

You stand there with your tortilla chips, a gallon of milk, a frozen pizza you are pretending is “for the kids,” and one of those tiny bags of shredded cheese that costs roughly the same as a used lawn mower. The machine tells you to place the item in the bagging area. You place the item in the bagging area. The machine then accuses you, in a tone normally reserved for federal investigations, of placing an unexpected item in the bagging area.

A light starts blinking.

A teenager in a vest wanders over, swipes a card, and clears the charge against your character. You say, “Thanks,” because you were raised by people who made you thank the person rescuing you from a computer that thinks you are running a nacho-based criminal enterprise.

Then, somewhere between the receipt printer wheezing like a 1987 dot-matrix machine and the guy behind you sighing because you apparently invented delay, you realize something: we have built a whole culture around machines that demand immediate compliance, assume bad faith, and make every small disagreement feel like a moral event.

That might explain a few things.

Right now, there is a strange pressure in the air to declare yourself. On everything. Immediately. Publicly. Loudly enough that no one mistakes your hesitation for betrayal.

Are you with us or against us?

Pick a side.

Silence is violence.

If you do not repost this, you are part of the problem.

And I don’t know. Maybe I just wanted to buy cheese.

This “you are either with me or against me” business has become one of the more exhausting features of modern life, and that is saying something in a time when refrigerators can send notifications and every streaming service wants me to remember a password I made during the Obama administration. It is not enough anymore to treat people decently, mind your business, raise your kids, pay your bills, help your neighbor shovel the driveway, and occasionally eat dinner without issuing a public statement. No, now you are supposed to join the parade, wear the shirt, use the slogan, update the profile picture, and drink deeply from the official ceremonial jug of Kool-Aid.

And to be fair, every generation has had its version of this. Human beings have always liked tribes. We like teams, uniforms, chants, inside jokes, shared villains, and the comforting feeling that we are the sane ones and everyone else is a few fries short of a happy meal.

But the current version feels different.

It feels faster. Meaner. More theatrical. It feels like a lot of younger adults, especially Millennials and Gen Z, were handed a world full of real problems, real corruption, real hypocrisy, and real pain, and instead of being taught how to think through those problems with patience and proportion, they were handed a digital megaphone and told that certainty is the same thing as courage.

That is not entirely their fault.

They grew up in a world where everything was recorded, sorted, ranked, liked, shared, stitched, clipped, and judged by strangers with usernames like DumpsterWizard47. They were taught that every opinion is a brand, every disagreement is content, and every awkward silence is proof of guilt. If you are twenty-three years old and all you have ever known is the internet court system, it probably makes sense that you think every conversation needs a verdict.

Still, some of us would like to object. Calmly. From a chair. With back support.

Because there is a difference between rejecting an idea and rejecting a person.

That difference used to be more obvious. Not perfectly obvious, because human beings have never been that impressive, but at least available. You could think your neighbor's politics were ridiculous and still lend him jumper cables. You could disagree with your cousin's life choices and still save him a seat at Thanksgiving, even if you strategically placed him near the mashed potatoes and far away from Grandpa, who had been watching cable news since breakfast and was loaded for bear. You could roll your eyes, mutter something in the garage, and then go back inside because family was family and not every conflict needed to become the Council of Nicaea.

Now, disagreement is often treated like hatred in waiting.

If I do not affirm every piece of your worldview, I must despise you. If I do not adopt your language, I must want you harmed. If I do not clap when the crazy train pulls into the station, I must be standing on the tracks with a sack of villainy and a little mustache.

But maybe I just think the train is going the wrong direction.

Maybe I am not against you. Maybe I am against the principle. Maybe I think the idea is wrong, or foolish, or harmful, or dishonest, or simply not something I can sign my name to without feeling like I left my brain unattended in a parking lot.

That does not mean I hate you as a human being.

This is where people get nervous, because we have forgotten how to separate dignity from agreement. We have started acting like love requires approval, respect requires endorsement, and kindness requires intellectual surrender. That is a dangerous trade. It makes all of us weaker. It turns friendship into a loyalty test and conversation into a hostage negotiation.

I do not want to live that way.

I am a big believer in the old, boring idea that people are still people even when they are wrong. I know. Wild stuff. Alert the authorities.

Not every priest is a saint. That should not be controversial to say, though for a long time plenty of people acted like it was. Some priests have been faithful, humble, sacrificial men who served people well and quietly for decades. Some have failed badly. Some have done terrible harm. The collar does not erase the person underneath it.

Not every police officer is lawful. Some are brave and decent and show up on the worst day of someone's life trying to keep things from becoming worse. Some abuse power. Some lie. Some protect their own when they should be protecting the public. A badge can represent order, but it does not magically produce virtue.

And yes, some teachers are wrong in what they are teaching. Many teachers are underpaid, overworked, and trying to hold civilization together with dry-erase markers and the last working copier in the building. Some are wonderful. Some are not. Some teach facts. Some teach opinions as if they were facts. Some confuse influence with education. A classroom is not holy ground just because there are motivational posters on the wall.

The point is not that priests, police officers, and teachers are bad. That would be lazy. The point is that roles do not make people automatically right. Institutions deserve respect when they are doing what they are supposed to do, but respect is not the same thing as blindness.

And the same rule applies everywhere.

I do not have to get behind every claim being made about gender to treat a confused or struggling person with basic human decency. I do not have to pretend I understand the furry community, because in true Rob fashion, I am still trying to understand why my phone needs eleven updates a month and why jeans now come pre-destroyed. I do not have to sign a lifetime membership card for every new collection of letters added to the LGBTQ-plus-whatever-club to believe that the people inside those conversations are human beings with souls, wounds, families, bills, memories, fears, and the right to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.

Within the confines of a functioning society, for sure. That part matters.

Because freedom does not mean every desire becomes a public command. It does not mean every private identity gets to rewrite everyone else's speech, conscience, religion, bathrooms, locker rooms, sports leagues, children's curriculum, and common sense by lunchtime on Tuesday. But it also does not mean we get to mock people into despair, strip them of dignity, or act like their existence is an inconvenience to our preferred version of normal.

Two things can be true.

That sentence may be the last surviving adult in the room.

Two things can be true. A person can be wrong and still deserve kindness. A movement can overreach and still include hurting people. A slogan can be manipulative and still point at a real wound. A tradition can be worth defending and still contain hypocrites. A young person can be sincerely searching and still

be sincerely mistaken. An older person can be right about one thing and still need to stop yelling at the government on the TV like it owes him money.

I include myself in that last one, just to keep the record honest.

The problem with “with me or against me” thinking is that it flattens everybody. It takes complicated human beings and turns them into cardboard signs. Friend. Enemy. Ally. Bigot. Hero. Coward. Victim. Oppressor. Approved. Canceled. The categories get simple because simple categories are easier to weaponize.

But people are not simple.

Most of us are a messy little casserole of good intentions, bad habits, half-formed opinions, old wounds, family loyalties, fears we have not admitted, and things we heard from an uncle in 1994 and have never fully checked. We are not always brave. We are not always fair. We are not always consistent. Some days we are principled. Some days we are just tired and hungry and one mildly inconvenient email away from becoming a historical cautionary tale.

That is why grace matters.

Not the cheap kind of grace that says nothing matters and everyone should just do whatever they want because “that’s their truth,” which is usually just moral laziness wearing yoga pants. I mean the harder kind of grace. The kind that tells the truth without turning people into targets. The kind that can say, “I think you are wrong,” without adding, “and therefore I am done seeing you as a person.”

We need more of that.

We need it at dinner tables, in churches, in schools, at work, online, and especially in those little comment sections where humanity goes to practice being terrible with punctuation. We need the ability to say no without hatred. We need the ability to hear no without calling it violence. We need to rebuild the muscle that lets us disagree without immediately reaching for the flamethrower.

And I understand why people want sides. Sides are clean. Sides give you a team. Sides tell you who to cheer for and who to blame. Sides make the world feel organized, especially when everything else feels like a junk drawer full of dead batteries and keys that open nothing.

But sides can also make us stupid.

Once you pick a side too completely, you start defending things you should be questioning (cough, cough, congress). You start excusing cruelty because it comes from your people. You start calling cowardice “strategy” and meanness “truth-telling.” You start believing the worst about anyone who hesitates. You stop asking, “Is this right?” and start asking, “Does this help my team?”

That is how decent people end up defending indecent things.

And at the end of the day, I am against that. I am against the principle. I am against the demand that every moral question be turned into a loyalty oath. I am against the idea that my refusal to drink your Kool-Aid means I wish you harm. I am against the emotional blackmail that says disagreement is violence,

hesitation is betrayal, and common sense is some dusty artifact we keep in the garage next to the Christmas lights.

I just want us to recover the idea that people can be wrong without being disposable.

That should not be radical. It should be the price of admission for living around other humans. We are all going to be wrong about something. Probably many things. Some of us are wrong before breakfast. Some of us are wrong with confidence, which is worse because then we add volume.

So maybe we could leave a little room.

Room for correction. Room for conversation. Room for the person who is not convinced yet. Room for the person who loves you but cannot follow you into every belief. Room for the parent trying to raise kids without surrendering to every trend that shows up wearing compassion as a costume. Room for the young adult trying to make sense of themselves without being used as a political mascot by people who do not actually know them.

Room for truth and mercy to exist in the same sentence.

That is really the whole thing. I do not have to join your club to care whether you are okay. I do not have to affirm every belief to defend your basic dignity. I do not have to board the crazy train to hope you get where you need to go safely.

I can be against the idea and still be for the person.